

Kerem Zaman

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

My research focuses on interpretable and explainable NLP, AI safety, reasoning, fairness, and robustness. My ultimate goal is to advance safe and transparent AI systems by deepening our understanding of black-box models. I am also broadly interested in reasoning in LLMs, multilingual NLP, and fairness.

EDUCATION

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

PhD in Computer Science

MS in Computer Science

Advisor: Prof. Shashank Srivastava

Chapel Hill, NC, USA

2022 – Present

2022 – 2025

Boğaziçi University

BSc in Computer Engineering

Istanbul, Turkey

2018 – 2022

PUBLICATIONS

Is Chain-of-Thought Really Not Explainability? Chain-of-Thought Can Be Faithful without Hint Verbalization

[Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava

ACL 2026 **ORAL**

DiffVax: Optimization-Free Image Immunization Against Diffusion-Based Editing

Tarik Can Ozden, Ozgur Kara, Oguzhan Akcin, [Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava, Sandeep P. Chinchali, James M. Rehg

ICLR 2026

A Causal Lens for Evaluating Faithfulness Metrics

[Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava

EMNLP 2025

INTERACT: Enabling Interactive, Question-Driven Learning in Large Language Models

Aum Kendapadi*, [Kerem Zaman](#)*, Rakesh R Menon*, Shashank Srivastava

ACL 2025 **ORAL**

Fuse to Forget: Bias Reduction and Selective Memorization through Model Fusion

[Kerem Zaman](#), Leshem Choshen, Shashank Srivastava

EMNLP 2024

MaNtLE: Model-agnostic Natural Language Explainer

Rakesh R Menon, [Kerem Zaman](#), Shashank Srivastava

EMNLP 2023

A Multilingual Perspective Towards the Evaluation of Attribution Methods

[Kerem Zaman](#), Yonatan Belinkov

EMNLP 2022 **ORAL**

Rank in Style: A Ranking-based Approach to Find Interpretable Directions in StyleGAN

Umut Kocasari*, [Kerem Zaman](#)*, Mert Tiftikci*, Pinar Yanardag

CVPR Workshop on Computer Vision for Fashion, Art, and Design 2022

BURST: Software and Simulation Solutions of an Autonomous Vehicle

Fatih Köse, İbrahim Özcan, Melih Dal, Metehan Yıldırım, Kadir Türksoy, [Kerem Zaman](#), Tuna Meral, Sinan Öncü

28th Signal Processing and Communications Applications Conference (SIU 2020)

EXPERIENCE

Google DeepMind

Student Researcher | Advisors: Neha Kalibhat & Mani Malek

New York City, NY, USA

May 2026 – Present

Interpreting model behaviors through mechanistic analysis.

UNC-NLP

Graduate Research Assistant | Advisor: Shashank Srivastava

Chapel Hill, NC, USA

August 2022 – Present

Research on explainable NLP, faithfulness of natural language explanations, safety, fairness, and model merging.

IFM MBZUAI Silicon Valley Lab

AI Engineering Intern | Advisor: Mikhail Yurochkin

Sunnyvale, CA, USA

May 2025 – August 2025

Improved domain-specific reasoning in LLMs by generating synthetic mid-training data through self-play.

CATLAB at Bogazici University

Undergraduate Research Assistant | Advisor: Pinar Yanardag

Istanbul, Turkey

October 2021 – June 2022

Improved text-based image manipulation for GANs using automatically extracted masks and enhanced text generation strategies.

Independent Research

Advisor: Yonatan Belinkov

Remote

April 2021 – June 2022

Evaluated attribution methods on the NLI task and developed a novel faithfulness evaluation method.

Independent Research

Advisor: Tolga Birdal

Remote

September 2021 – September 2022

Explored Riemannian alternatives to GANs, including interpolation, random walk, and latent space manipulation.

PragmaCraft

Software Engineer / Software Engineer Intern

Istanbul, Turkey

July 2018 – June 2022

Built and deployed NLP pipelines for retrieval, QA, NER, summarization, and text classification.

INVITED TALKS

Northeastern University (Byron Wallace's group)

April 2026

Is CoT Really Not Explainability? CoT Can Be Faithful without Hint-Verbalization

Koç University (GGLab)

December 2022

A Multilingual Perspective on Evaluating Attribution Methods in NLI

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Reviewer: ICLR 2025, ACL Rolling Review (ARR) 2024–2026, DaSH Workshop @ EMNLP 2022

Outstanding Reviewer, EMNLP 2025 (top <1%)

AWARDS

Research funding from *Coefficient Giving* for work on reasoning circuits in LLMs

Most Original Software Award, Teknofest Robotaxi Full-Scale Autonomous Vehicle Competition (2021)

1st Place, Preliminary Design & Simulation Stage, Teknofest Robotaxi Competition (2019 & 2020)

242nd out of 2M+ students, Turkish University Entrance Exam (2018)

3rd Place, Istanbul-Asia Region, TÜBİTAK Research Projects Challenge for High School Students

OTHER

Bogazici University Robotic Systems Team — Autonomous EV Project (2018–2022)

Led the Autonomous Software Team (2020–2022); developed path planning and control systems, contributed to traffic sign detection, and validated the full pipeline in simulation and on the real vehicle.